

5. Working with Files and Folders

When working with data, file organization matters.

If your files are organized, R can find them more easily.

What is a Working Directory?

The **working directory** is the folder where R is currently looking for files.

If you ask R to open a file, R first looks in the working directory.

For example:

```
read.csv("mydata.csv")
```

This tells R:

Look in the current working directory for a file called `mydata.csv`.

Checking Your Working Directory

You can check your working directory with:

```
getwd()
```

```
[1] "/Users/ylim2/Documents/01_Work/01_MA213/R_onboarding/R_onboarding_repo/R_Onboarding"
```

This prints the folder where R is currently working.

Tip

If R cannot find your file, checking `getwd()` is often the first thing to do.

File Names Matter

Good file names are short and clear.

Good examples:

```
mydata.csv  
first_script.R  
lab_report.qmd
```

Less helpful examples:

```
Untitled1.R  
final final data copy.csv  
my data file.csv
```

Tip

Avoid spaces in file names.
Use underscores `_` instead:

```
my_data.csv  
lab_report.qmd
```

Try It Yourself

Practice

1. Create a folder for this course.
2. Inside it, create a folder for this assignment or lab.
3. Save your R script in that folder.
4. In RStudio, run:

```
getwd()
```

5. Check whether R is working in the folder you expected.

Common Mistake

Warning

Avoid saving course files only in your Downloads folder.
The Downloads folder can become messy quickly, and files may be hard to find later.

Check Your Understanding

Answer these questions:

1. What is a working directory?
2. Why is it helpful to keep your script and data file in the same folder?
3. What command shows the current working directory?
4. Why should you avoid unclear file names?

Summary

In this section, you learned that:

- The working directory is where R looks for files.
- `getwd()` shows your current working directory.
- Clear file names help prevent mistakes. “““